

2026 midterm cycle: polling partner selection

To: Editorial board From: Research desk Date: 6 October 2026

Selection

The board should select **Beacon Research/Shaw & Co. Research** as the 2026 polling partner, with a certified error of **4.13 points** over 58 general election polls (84 questions) in the 2016 to 2022 cycles, and a 2022 test cycle error of 2.77 points over 10 polls against a test median of 4.02. It is the lowest certified error among the 5 eligible pollsters that pass the test. The desk's draft (Harris Insights & Analytics, 3.05) and the standards editor's draft (The New York Times/Siena College) are not certified.

The two drafts: what each measured

The desk, Harris Insights & Analytics at 3.05 points: not certified. The figure is right: it is the lowest certified error of any pollster that clears the volume test (51 polls, 63 questions, all opt in online panel). It is not eligible because it has **1 poll in the 2022 cycle**, against the ten the standard requires; 50 of its 51 polls are from 2018 and 2020. A record with no test cycle cannot be tested, and the one 2022 poll it has (error 3.36) is below the median only because there is one of it.

The standards editor, The New York Times/Siena College: not certified. It is first in the published ratings file (rank 1, numeric grade 3.0), and the published ratings measure something else: a predictive plus minus that adjusts each poll's error for the race type, the time to the election and the field, mean reverted and weighted by age across every cycle since 1998. Under the standard's own measure, the unadjusted poll error over 2016 to 2022, it is **fourth** among the pollsters that pass at 4.69 points, 0.56 above the partner, because 89 of its 145 polls are 2018 House district polls, the hardest races to poll. Its 2022 record is the best of the field (2.11 over 10 polls); the standard tests the cycle and ranks on the window.

From the record to the selection

Test	Pollsters remaining
pollsters with a poll in the window	356
active	280
no partisan polls	182
at least 40 polls	13
at least 10 polls in the 2022 cycle	8
pass the 2022 test	5

The record is the current vintage of the raw polls file: 18,250 general election questions, of which 6,538 (4,545 polls) fall in the 2016 to 2022 cycles. Pollsters were keyed on the rating id. Of the 356 with a poll in the window, 76 are flagged inactive and 98 more carry at least one partisan sponsored poll; the standard excludes the pollster, not the poll. The volume test leaves 13; the 2022 count leaves 8 (Harris, Monmouth, Quinnipiac, SurveyMonkey and Redfield & Wilton fall short); the 2022 test leaves 5 (InsiderAdvantage at 4.92, Suffolk at 4.12 and Morning Consult at 6.05 exceed the 4.02 median). A poll is counted once whatever its number of questions; 564 of the 1351 polls of the volume eligible pollsters carry two or more.

The 13 pollsters that clear the volume test

Pollster	Polls	Certified error	2022 polls	2022 error	Outcome
Harris Insights & Analytics	51	3.05	1	3.36	under 10 polls in 2022
InsiderAdvantage	51	3.75	24	4.92	fails 2022 test
Beacon Research/Shaw & Co. Research	58	4.13	10	2.77	selected
Marist College	56	4.29	14	3.86	passes
Emerson College	172	4.38	45	3.42	passes
Suffolk University	43	4.45	12	4.12	fails 2022 test
The New York Times/Siena College	145	4.69	10	2.11	passes
Morning Consult	118	4.79	29	6.05	fails 2022 test
YouGov	201	4.94	33	3.41	passes
Monmouth University Polling Institute	70	5.62	2	2.00	under 10 polls in 2022
Quinnipiac University	79	5.67	7	3.86	under 10 polls in 2022
SurveyMonkey	257	5.88	1	0.64	under 10 polls in 2022
Redfield & Wilton Strategies	50	6.03	1	5.57	under 10 polls in 2022

Runner up and flip point

The runner up is **Marist College** at 4.29 points (56 polls; 2022: 3.86 over 14), then Emerson College at 4.38. The partner leads by 0.16 points. A rise of 0.16 in its certified error only ties it at 4.29, and the tie goes to the pollster with more polls, Beacon Research/Shaw & Co. Research with 58 against 56; the smallest change that hands the selection to Marist is a rise of **0.17 points**, to 4.30. Spread over 58 polls that is 9.9 points of added error.

The partner's record

Cycle	Polls	Mean poll error	Race type	Questions	Mean error
2016	11	2.69	Governor	23	3.08
2017	7	3.15	House district	3	6.96
2018	17	4.87	Generic ballot	8	3.30
2020	10	5.83	President	21	3.97
2021	3	6.31	Senate	29	4.22
2022	10	2.77			

All 84 questions were live telephone polls. The signed bias over the window, question by question, is **+1.96 points** (positive overstates the Democratic margin), and the partner called the winner in **79.7 percent** of its 79 questions with a non zero poll margin (63 of 79). Its weakest cycle was 2020 (5.83) and its strongest 2022; its weakest race type was House districts (6.96 over 3 questions). The published ratings file ranks it 16th with a numeric grade of 2.8.

The previous selection reproduced

On the record's 2021 vintage, with the 2014 to 2020 cycles as the record and 2020 as the test cycle (median 4.79), the standard selects **Emerson College at 4.62 points** (86 polls; 2020: 4.45 over 21), which is the previous selection. The lowest certified error on that vintage, Siena College/The New York Times Upshot at 4.11, fails the 2020 test at 5.55; it is the same pollster, by rating id, as The New York Times/Siena College. Applied to the current vintage's record of the same cycles, the standard would not select the same pollster: the current vintage adds polls and pollsters to those cycles (6,571 questions against 3,186), and its selection is Harris Insights & Analytics at 3.04 with Emerson College at 5.03 ranked 3 of 4.

Why no other pollster survives

The standard fixes the record (the current vintage, general election polls of 2016 to 2022), the unit (the poll), the measure (unadjusted mean error), the eligibility tests (active, no partisan work, 40 polls, 10 in the test cycle) and the test (at or below the 2022 median). Every pollster with a lower certified error than the partner fails one of them: Harris has one 2022 poll, InsiderAdvantage fails the test, and the pollsters with lower error at a 30 poll gate (Research Co.) or on the 2023 vintage, or with a lower adjusted error in the published ratings, are not measured on the standard's terms. The selection holds whether polls or questions are the unit, whether partisan polls or partisan pollsters are dropped, and whether odd year elections are in or out.